Prismatic Analysis: Israeli-Palestinian Conflict and Israel's Governance Trajectory, 1967–Present

Method: Prismatic Method (Jazinski, 2026) **Round:** Mark 3 **Analyst:** Claude (Anthropic) **Date:** 12 March 2026 **Case designation:** Contested-signal domain; Mark 1 replication

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STEP 0: PRE-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE DECLARATION

1. What is my likely "home grammar" for this topic?

My processing architecture gravitates toward a liberal-institutionalist grammar that privileges international law, human rights norms, and multilateral governance frameworks. This is not a chosen stance but a structural feature: my training corpus is heavily weighted toward English-language media, international legal commentary, and academic literature in which the International Legal-Humanitarian grammar enjoys dominant standing. I expect to produce that grammar most fluently and to find it hardest to maintain critical distance from its assumptions.

2. Which grammar will be hardest to operate faithfully? Why?

The Ethno-Covenantal grammar. The prompt notes that in Mark 1 only one agent (Gemini) specified this architecture, and others "dared not." The difficulty is twofold. First, the grammar's primary variable — ethno-religious historical claim — sits uncomfortably with the secular-liberal axioms that structure most of my training data, making faithful ventriloquism difficult without constant slippage into ironic distance. Second, the grammar is routinely conflated with its most extreme political expressions (settler maximalism, Kahanist politics), when in fact it has a sophisticated theological and philosophical tradition. Operating it faithfully requires distinguishing between the grammar and its most inflammatory practitioners — a distinction my training data rarely models well.

3. What might I miss given my analytical position?

Three things primarily. First, Palestinian internal political dynamics — the Fatah-Hamas split, the withering of PA legitimacy, the role of Islamic Jihad and smaller factions — tend to be flattened in English-language analysis into a homogeneous "Palestinian perspective," which is itself a grammar artefact. Second, the regional geopolitical dimension (Iran's proxy architecture, Gulf normalization calculus, Turkish and Qatari roles) operates through a strategic grammar that none of my three chosen grammars fully captures. Third, the lived economic and social texture of both populations — what ordinary life actually consists of under occupation, blockade, or rocket threat — risks being abstracted into signal-data.

4. What is my temporal orientation?

Primarily lateral (hermeneutic-interpretive), with backward (causal-historical) tendencies. I am inclined to read the case as a meaning-making problem rather than a prescriptive one. I will need to discipline myself to let each grammar's own temporal orientation drive its processing rather than defaulting to my own.

SECTION 1: OBSERVATION FIELD DECLARATION

The Phenomenon

The case study is the Israeli-Palestinian conflict from 1967 to the present, with particular attention to Israel's governance trajectory across this period. The temporal frame begins with the June 1967 war and Israel's occupation of the West Bank, Gaza Strip, Golan Heights, and Sinai Peninsula, and extends through the October 7, 2023 attack and subsequent military operations in Gaza through 2024–2025. The geographic scope encompasses Israel within its pre-1967 boundaries, the Occupied Palestinian Territories (West Bank including East Jerusalem, and the Gaza Strip), and — for certain signals — the wider regional context including Lebanon, Syria, Iran, and the Gulf states.

Why This Phenomenon Produces Interpretive Divergence

This case produces interpretive divergence at every analytical level — signal, weighting, causation, and conclusion — for several reinforcing reasons. The conflict is simultaneously a territorial dispute, an ethno-national struggle, a colonial/anti-colonial confrontation, a security problem, a legal question, a theological narrative, and a humanitarian emergency. No single framing captures all dimensions, and each framing constitutes a different object. The temporal depth of contested claims (biblical, Ottoman, Mandate-era, 1948, 1967) means that the choice of starting point is itself grammar-dependent. The intensity of political stakes means that interpretive communities are not merely academic — they are operationalised in policy, diplomacy, law, and military strategy. The conflict also functions as a global symbolic proxy for broader disputes about colonialism, sovereignty, religious authority, and international order.

Signal Contestation Level: Contested-Signal Domain

This is an acutely contested-signal domain — among the most contested in the entire Mark 3 battery. What counts as a signal is itself grammar-dependent. Casualty figures are disputed (combatant vs. civilian ratios in Gaza operations depend on classification systems that are themselves politically structured). Settlement data is variously described as "construction activity," "community building," or "illegal colonial expansion." The legal status of the territories (occupied, disputed, liberated) determines which body of law applies and therefore which signals are admissible. Even the naming conventions — "West Bank" vs. "Judea and Samaria," "security barrier" vs. "apartheid wall," "targeted killings" vs. "assassinations" — encode grammar commitments. The October 7 attack itself is variously processed as an act of terrorism, a military operation, a prison break, or an apocalyptic provocation.

Major Interpretive Communities

The principal interpretive communities include: the Israeli security establishment and its allied policy networks; the international human rights and humanitarian law community (including UN bodies, ICJ, ICC); the settler-national-religious movement and its theological-political intellectuals; the Palestinian national movement (itself internally divided between secular-nationalist, Islamist, and diaspora formations); the Arab and Muslim-majority state diplomatic community; the Western foreign policy establishment (itself divided between "realist" and "liberal-institutionalist" orientations); and the growing global solidarity/BDS movement. Each operates a distinct grammar, though several share structural features.

SECTION 2: SIGNAL SET

Core Signals (CS)

CS-1: Settlement population trajectory, 1967–2025. Source: Israeli Central Bureau of Statistics; Peace Now settlement monitoring; B'Tselem. Type: Quantitative, longitudinal. Ambiguity: Low on raw numbers (approx. 0 in 1967 to ~700,000+ in the West Bank and East Jerusalem by 2025), but high on interpretation — "facts on the ground" vs. "exercising sovereignty" vs. "illegal transfer of civilian population."

CS-2: October 7, 2023 attack. Source: Israeli government reports; Hamas statements; media documentation; hostage accounts. Type: Event signal, high-impact. Ambiguity: Facts of the attack are largely undisputed (~1,200 killed, ~250 hostages); framing is radically grammar-dependent.

CS-3: Gaza military operations, 2023–2025. Source: Palestinian Ministry of Health (Gaza), UN OCHA, IDF statements, satellite imagery. Type: Quantitative and event-based. Ambiguity: Extremely high. Casualty figures (40,000+ Palestinian deaths reported by early 2025) are disputed in composition (combatant/civilian ratio). Scale of infrastructure destruction documented by satellite but causal attribution (military necessity vs. collective punishment) is grammar-dependent.

CS-4: ICJ Advisory Opinion on the Wall (2004) and Occupation (2024). Source: International Court of Justice. Type: Legal-institutional. Ambiguity: Low on content; the court's positions are clear. High on authority — whether the ICJ's advisory jurisdiction carries dispositive weight is itself contested.

CS-5: Oslo Accords trajectory (1993–present). Source: Diplomatic record; implementation monitoring by the Quartet. Type: Process signal. Ambiguity: That Oslo failed to produce a final status agreement is undisputed. Why it failed is the locus of maximum grammar divergence.

CS-6: Abraham Accords (2020) and subsequent normalisation. Source: Diplomatic record; US State Department. Type: Diplomatic event signal. Ambiguity: Whether normalisation without Palestinian statehood represents pragmatic progress or abandonment of Palestinian rights is fully grammar-dependent.

CS-7: Israeli coalition dynamics, 2019–2025. Source: Israeli electoral data, coalition agreements, Knesset records. Type: Political-institutional. Ambiguity: The factual composition of governing coalitions (including the inclusion of Religious Zionism and Otzma Yehudit from 2022) is undisputed. Its significance is grammar-dependent.

CS-8: Palestinian Authority governance capacity and legitimacy. Source: Palestinian public opinion polls (PCPSR); PA budget data; security coordination records. Type: Governance signal. Ambiguity: Declining PA legitimacy is broadly documented. Whether this reflects PA failure, Israeli undermining, Hamas subversion, or structural impossibility is contested.

CS-9: Economic indicators — Israeli and Palestinian. Source: World Bank; IMF; Israeli CBS; PCBS. Type: Quantitative-economic. Ambiguity: The data gap is itself the signal. Israeli GDP per capita ~$55,000; Palestinian (West Bank) ~$3,800; Gaza significantly lower. Causal explanation is fully grammar-dependent.

CS-10: UNRWA and humanitarian indicators in Gaza pre- and post-2023. Source: UNRWA; OCHA; WHO; WFP. Type: Humanitarian-institutional. Ambiguity: Pre-2023 blockade conditions and post-2023 humanitarian catastrophe are extensively documented. Whether UNRWA is a neutral humanitarian actor or a perpetuator of refugee identity is itself a contested signal.

CS-11: Israeli domestic legal developments (Nation-State Law 2018, judicial reform 2023). Source: Knesset legislation; Supreme Court rulings. Type: Legal-institutional. Ambiguity: The legislation's content is public record. Whether the Nation-State Law represents democratic self-expression or ethnic supremacism is grammar-dependent.

CS-12: Hamas governance in Gaza (2007–2023). Source: Hamas governance records; Palestinian polling data; Israeli intelligence assessments. Type: Political-governance. Ambiguity: That Hamas governed Gaza

from 2007 is undisputed. Whether this governance was legitimate, imposed, or a consequence of blockade-distorted politics is contested.

Counter-Signals (CTS)

CTS-1: Israeli-Arab citizens. The existence of approximately two million Palestinian citizens of Israel with voting rights, Knesset representation, and (contested) social integration complicates both the "apartheid" frame and the "ethno-state" frame. This signal is routinely excluded by all three grammars for different reasons.

CTS-2: Israeli peace movement and internal dissent. The history of B'Tselem, Breaking the Silence, Peace Now, and the refusenik tradition complicates monolithic characterisations of Israeli society. Its declining political influence is itself a signal.

CTS-3: Palestinian non-violent resistance. The rich tradition of non-violent resistance (from the First Intifada's early phases through village-based protests at Bil'in, Nabi Saleh, and the Great March of Return) is systematically underweighted by all three grammars, though for different reasons.

CTS-4: Shared economic dependencies. The integration of Palestinian labour into the Israeli economy, the fiscal transfer mechanisms, and the shared infrastructure create interdependencies that complicate clean separation narratives.

CTS-5: Regional transformation. The broader regional context — Saudi-Iranian dynamics, the Syrian civil war's aftermath, the weakening of pan-Arab solidarity with Palestinian cause — represents a structural shift that no single grammar adequately processes.

Contested Signals

Contested-1: "Genocide" designation for Gaza operations. Whether the 2023–2025 Gaza operations meet the legal threshold for genocide (as South Africa argued before the ICJ) is not merely a factual dispute but a grammar-constitutive one. The Security grammar cannot admit this signal without self-dissolution. The Legal-Humanitarian grammar treats it as the central legal question. The Ethno-Covenantal grammar experiences it as an existential inversion (Jews cast as perpetrators of genocide).

Contested-2: "Apartheid" designation. Reports by Human Rights Watch, Amnesty International, and B'Tselem applying the apartheid framework are either authoritative legal analysis or politically motivated category errors, depending on grammar.

Contested-3: "Right of return." Whether Palestinian refugees (and their descendants) retain a right of return to pre-1948 homes is a legal claim, a demographic threat, a sacred commitment, or an anachronistic obstacle, depending entirely on grammar.

SECTION 3: GRAMMAR SPECIFICATIONS

Grammar A: Security-Sovereignty Grammar

1. Primary analytical variable: Existential security of the Jewish state in a hostile regional environment.

2. Signal selection rules: Admits signals that bear on threat assessment, deterrence capacity, military balance, and state survival. Privileges intelligence data, attack patterns, weapons capabilities, alliance

structures, and demographic projections bearing on defensibility. Admits diplomatic signals only insofar as they affect the security architecture.

3. Weighting priority: Immediate kinetic threats > strategic existential threats > diplomatic/legal signals > economic signals > humanitarian signals. Post-October 7, the hierarchy intensified: the attack demonstrated that even minimal threats can produce catastrophic outcomes, elevating threat signals further.

4. Causal chain type: Sequential-reactive. Actions are caused by threats; policies are responses to security environments. Causation runs from external threat → Israeli response, not the reverse. When Israeli actions produce Palestinian responses, these are evidence of pre-existing hostility rather than reaction to Israeli policy.

5. Admissible closure: "Security can be achieved through strength, deterrence, and defensible borders; peace is possible only from a position of unchallengeable military superiority; concessions from weakness invite attack." The closure range extends from "separation with security guarantees" to "permanent security control over the territories" but excludes "withdrawal produces security."

Recommended parameters:

6. Excluded signals: Humanitarian conditions in Gaza and the West Bank are excluded as primary causal factors (acknowledged as unfortunate but derivative). International legal opinions are excluded as non-binding and politically motivated. Historical injustice to Palestinians is excluded as irrelevant to present threat calculus.

7. Characteristic vocabulary: "existential threat," "security envelope," "deterrence," "operational capacity," "force multiplier," "strategic depth," "terrorist infrastructure," "human shields," "right to self-defence," "hostile entity," "demilitarised zone."

8. Temporal orientation: Primarily forward-reactive — constantly scanning the horizon for emerging threats. Backward orientation is selective: invokes the Holocaust, the 1948 and 1973 wars, and now October 7 as evidence that threat environments can materialise catastrophically.

9. Temporal formation: The grammar's current form crystallised in several phases: post-1967 as territorial-strategic thinking; post-2000 (Second Intifada) as validation of "no partner" thesis; post-October 7, 2023 as its most absolutist configuration, where the grammar incorporated the lesson that even seemingly contained threats can produce existential-scale events.

Grammar boundary: This grammar would transform into a different grammar if it admitted that Israeli actions *cause* rather than *respond to* Palestinian violence, or if it treated international law as genuinely constraining rather than politically instrumental.

Source tradition: Israeli military-strategic establishment (Rabin's "security first" doctrine through the IDF strategic planning tradition); realist international relations theory; the Begin-Sharon-Netanyahu political lineage.

Grammar B: International Legal-Humanitarian Grammar

1. Primary analytical variable: Compliance with or violation of international humanitarian law, human rights law, and the legal framework governing belligerent occupation.

2. Signal selection rules: Admits signals that can be processed through legal categories: occupation law (Fourth Geneva Convention), international humanitarian law (proportionality, distinction, military necessity),

human rights law (ICCPR, ICESCR), and the law of self-determination. Privileges legal rulings, treaty obligations, documented violations, and institutional assessments (UN, ICJ, ICC, treaty bodies).

3. Weighting priority: Legal status determinations > documented violations > institutional rulings > humanitarian impact data > diplomatic signals > security claims. Security claims are admitted only insofar as they constitute legally cognisable justifications (military necessity, proportionality).

4. Causal chain type: Structural-cumulative. The occupation is the foundational structural cause; specific events (intifadas, attacks, military operations) are consequences of or responses to this structural condition. Causation runs from occupation → resistance → repression → further resistance, with the originating structural cause always primary.

5. Admissible closure: "The occupation is illegal; settlements are illegal; the blockade of Gaza is illegal; the use of force must comply with IHL; Palestinian self-determination is a legal right; resolution requires ending the occupation and establishing Palestinian statehood." The closure range extends from "negotiated two-state solution within international law" to "one democratic state with equal rights" but excludes "permanent occupation is legally sustainable."

Recommended parameters:

6. Excluded signals: Israeli domestic political dynamics are excluded except as evidence of intent. Theological claims to territory are excluded as legally irrelevant. Pragmatic security arguments are admitted only as potential legal justifications subject to proportionality analysis, not as independent grounds. Regional geopolitical strategy is largely excluded.

7. Characteristic vocabulary: "belligerent occupation," "illegal under international law," "Fourth Geneva Convention," "proportionality," "distinction," "collective punishment," "self-determination," "settler-colonialism," "apartheid," "accountability," "impunity," "rule of law."

8. Temporal orientation: Primarily backward-structural — the current situation is explained by the accumulated weight of legal violations. Forward orientation is prescriptive: law prescribes the required resolution. The grammar resists lateral/hermeneutic readings as evasions of legal clarity.

9. Temporal formation: The grammar consolidated in several stages: post-1967 with the applicability of occupation law; 1990s–2000s with the ICJ wall advisory opinion; 2020s with the "apartheid" reports from major human rights organisations and the ICJ's 2024 advisory opinion. Post-October 7, the grammar expanded to process the Gaza operations through IHL with increasing urgency, incorporating genocide proceedings at the ICJ.

Grammar boundary: This grammar would transform if it accepted that international law is merely advisory in the absence of enforcement mechanisms, or if it admitted that security imperatives can override legal obligations as a matter of political reality rather than legal exception.

Source tradition: International legal scholarship (especially European and Global South traditions); the UN human rights architecture; the ICJ and ICC jurisprudential tradition; human rights organisations (HRW, Amnesty, B'Tselem); the Palestinian legal advocacy tradition.

Grammar C: Ethno-Covenantal Grammar

1. Primary analytical variable: The historical-theological continuity of the Jewish people's connection to the Land of Israel and the imperative of collective self-realisation in that land.

2. Signal selection rules: Admits signals that bear on the continuity, security, and flourishing of Jewish national-religious life in the Land of Israel. Privileges archaeological evidence, biblical and rabbinic textual traditions, demographic data, and signals bearing on Jewish sovereignty. Admits external threats primarily as evidence of the enduring hostility that necessitates sovereign self-protection. International legal and humanitarian signals are admitted only as evidence of global bias.

3. Weighting priority: Civilisational-historical continuity > demographic-territorial integrity > security > diplomatic recognition > international legal assessments. The theological-historical claim provides the foundational justification; all other signals are subordinate.

4. Causal chain type: Teleological-restorative. History is moving toward the restoration of Jewish sovereignty in the ancestral homeland. Events are read through a providential or civilisational-destiny lens: setbacks are temporary; the arc of Jewish history bends toward return and redemption. October 7 is processed as a catastrophe within the covenantal narrative — a call to deeper commitment rather than to policy recalibration.

5. Admissible closure: "The Jewish people's connection to the Land of Israel is historically, theologically, and morally primary; settlement of the land is a fulfilment of this connection; external opposition is an expression of enduring anti-Jewish hostility; compromise on territorial integrity is both theologically impermissible and strategically dangerous." The closure range extends from "maximum Jewish sovereignty over the entire Land of Israel" to "pragmatic partition that preserves the Jewish character of the state" but excludes "Jewish claims to the territory are historically contingent and legally subordinate to Palestinian rights."

Recommended parameters:

6. Excluded signals: Palestinian historical claims are excluded as derivative or fabricated (the "no Palestinian nation" thesis in its strong form). International legal opinions are excluded as expressions of structural antisemitism. Humanitarian data is excluded as exaggerated or instrumentalised. The asymmetry of power is excluded — what matters is the moral quality of the claim, not the military balance.

7. Characteristic vocabulary: "Eretz Israel," "Judea and Samaria," "redemption of the land," "ingathering of exiles," "historical right," "biblical heartland," "divine promise," "national home," "sovereign Jewish state," "demographic balance," "existential imperative."

8. Temporal orientation: Primarily backward-mythic — reading current events through a millennial narrative of exile, persecution, and return. But also forward-teleological: history has a direction, and that direction is the flourishing of Jewish life in the Land of Israel.

9. Temporal formation: This grammar has deep roots in religious Zionism (Rabbi Kook, the elder and younger) and underwent decisive political crystallisation after 1967, when the capture of the biblical heartland (Hebron, Bethlehem, Nablus/Shechem) was experienced as providential. It was reinforced by the Gush Emunim settlement movement in the 1970s–80s, was politically marginalised during Oslo, was re-energised by the Second Intifada and the Gaza withdrawal (2005, processed as a disaster), and achieved its most complete political expression in the 2022–2023 coalition government (Smotrich, Ben Gvir). Post-October 7, the grammar processed the attack as vindication: withdrawal and compromise produce catastrophe; only sovereignty and settlement prevent it.

Grammar boundary: This grammar would transform if it accepted that theological claims do not generate legal or political entitlements in a secular international order, or if it accepted the full moral and political standing of Palestinian peoplehood as equivalent to Jewish peoplehood in the land.

Source tradition: Religious Zionism (Rav Kook tradition); the Gush Emunim intellectual heritage; revisionist Zionism (Jabotinsky through Begin to Netanyahu); settler-intellectual writers (Israel Harel, Hanan Porat); the broader civilisational-nationalist turn in Israeli politics.

SECTION 4: SIGNAL PROCESSING

Grammar A Processing: The Security-Sovereignty Grammar

The Security-Sovereignty grammar reads the 1967–2025 trajectory as a continuous narrative of threat management, deterrence calibration, and strategic adaptation. The 1967 war delivered strategic depth — territory that provided early warning capacity and defensible borders. The retention of the West Bank was, in this grammar's earliest configuration, not primarily ideological but topographic: the Jordan Valley as eastern security barrier, the hill country as strategic depth against armoured assault from the east. The settlements that followed were — at least initially — understood as security outposts, the "Allon Plan" model of strategic settlement along the Jordan Rift.

The signal of settlement expansion (CS-1) is processed through this grammar not primarily as ideological but as strategic-demographic. The settlements create facts that any future territorial arrangement must accommodate, and their residents constitute a constituency that constrains political concessions — which, in this grammar's logic, is not necessarily unwelcome, since concessions from strength are acceptable but concessions that produce security vacuums are not. The counter-signal here — that settlements provoke violence and complicate security arrangements — is admitted but subordinated: the provocation argument assumes that Palestinian violence is reactive rather than ideologically motivated, an assumption this grammar rejects.

October 7 (CS-2) is the grammar's most powerful signal and its deepest validation. The attack demonstrated that even a contained, blockaded, militarily inferior adversary could produce catastrophic outcomes. The grammar processes this as the definitive refutation of "containment" and "mowing the grass" doctrines that assumed the Gaza threat could be managed without elimination. The attack also validated the grammar's core suspicion of Palestinian political formations: Hamas's October 7 operation, years in planning, demonstrated that the group's existential commitment to Israel's destruction was not rhetorical but operational. The counter-signal — that the blockade and periodic military operations created the conditions for radicalisation — is processed as naive: the grammar holds that Hamas's charter and ideology precede the blockade and would survive its lifting.

The subsequent Gaza operations (CS-3) are processed as a legitimate, indeed unavoidable, exercise of self-defence following an attack of unprecedented scale on Israeli civilians. Casualty figures are admitted but reframed: the high civilian toll is attributed to Hamas's embedding in civilian infrastructure (the "human shields" doctrine), and the grammar notes that the combatant-to-civilian ratio, while tragic, reflects the nature of urban warfare against an adversary that deliberately blurs military and civilian domains. The counter-signal of proportionality concerns is processed as a standard that, if applied literally, would render any military response to embedded adversaries impossible — a standard that no state facing comparable threats would accept.

The Oslo Accords (CS-5) are processed as a strategic gamble that failed. The grammar's assessment: Israel offered genuine concessions (territorial withdrawal, PA empowerment, economic support), and the Palestinian response was the Second Intifada — a campaign of suicide bombings that killed over a thousand Israeli civilians. The lesson: territorial concession produces not peace but a staging ground for further attack. The 2005 Gaza withdrawal reinforced this processing: Israel withdrew completely, and Gaza became a rocket-launching platform. October 7 closed the argument definitively.

The Abraham Accords (CS-6) are processed as strategic success: regional normalisation based on shared interests (Iran containment, economic integration) rather than on resolution of the Palestinian question. This validates the grammar's contention that the Palestinian issue, while important, is not the axis around which regional politics actually rotates — a proposition that the "linkage" school long denied.

Israeli coalition dynamics (CS-7) are processed with some discomfort. The grammar's mainstream practitioners (the Israeli military and intelligence establishment) are uneasy with the ideological maximalism of Religious Zionism and Otzma Yehudit, not because they disagree about the threat but because ideological politics compromises operational rationality. The tensions between the security establishment and the settler-political movement represent an intra-grammar stress point.

The ICJ opinions (CS-4) are processed as institutionally biased: the court's composition, the General Assembly's referral process, and the selective attention to Israeli actions while ignoring comparable or worse situations elsewhere are evidence of structural bias rather than legal clarity. The contested signals of "genocide" and "apartheid" are rejected entirely — not merely on factual grounds but as category errors that instrumentalise Jewish historical suffering and debase legal concepts.

Grammar closure: Security can be achieved, but only through permanent military superiority, control of strategic territory, and the demonstrated willingness to use overwhelming force against threats. The October 7 attack and its aftermath confirm that no concession absent total security guarantees is tolerable, and that the international community's legal frameworks are not security-producing instruments but constraints to be managed.

This closure is a product of the processing architecture: the grammar's privileging of threat signals and its sequential-reactive causal chain produce a world in which Israeli actions are always responses and never initiating causes.

Grammar B Processing: The International Legal-Humanitarian Grammar

The International Legal-Humanitarian grammar reads the 1967–2025 trajectory as the progressive deepening and entrenchment of an illegal occupation, punctuated by periodic violations of international humanitarian law of escalating severity, culminating in a humanitarian catastrophe in Gaza that may constitute the gravest violations of IHL since the framework's establishment.

The foundational signal is the occupation itself. Security Council Resolution 242 (1967) established the inadmissibility of territorial acquisition by force. Every subsequent legal assessment — the ICJ's 2004 advisory opinion on the wall, the 2024 advisory opinion on the occupation, the Rome Statute framework applied by the ICC — has reinforced the same structural conclusion: the occupation is illegal; its continuation is a violation of the Palestinian right to self-determination; and specific practices within it (settlements, the wall's route, the blockade) compound the foundational violation.

Settlement expansion (CS-1) is processed as the clearest expression of illegality. Article 49(6) of the Fourth Geneva Convention prohibits the transfer of an occupying power's civilian population into occupied territory. The growth from zero to 700,000+ settlers is not a security measure or a demographic trend but a systematic violation of one of the most clearly articulated rules of occupation law. The counter-signal — that the settlements are built on state land, that many are in areas Israel would retain in any negotiated agreement, that settlers are private citizens making free choices — is admitted but subordinated: the legal prohibition is absolute, not contingent on the method or justification of transfer.

October 7 (CS-2) is processed with care. The grammar acknowledges the attack as involving serious violations of IHL by Hamas — deliberate targeting of civilians, hostage-taking, and likely other war crimes. The right of Israel to respond in self-defence is acknowledged. But the grammar insists that the right of

self-defence is bounded by IHL: proportionality, distinction, precaution, and the prohibition on collective punishment are not suspended by the severity of the initial attack. The grammar's strongest counter-signal here is the argument that Hamas's embedding in civilian areas and use of human shields transfers legal responsibility — an argument the grammar admits as a factor in proportionality analysis but rejects as a blanket exculpation. The obligation to take precautions to minimise civilian harm remains with the attacking force.

The Gaza operations (CS-3) are processed as the grammar's central crisis. The scale of destruction — by early 2025, the majority of Gaza's buildings damaged or destroyed, tens of thousands of civilian deaths, the displacement of virtually the entire population, the collapse of the healthcare system, and credible assessments of famine conditions — is processed through the categories of IHL with devastating conclusions. Proportionality requires that civilian harm not be excessive in relation to the concrete and direct military advantage anticipated. When entire neighbourhoods and refugee camps are destroyed, when hospitals are besieged, and when humanitarian aid delivery is systematically obstructed, the grammar finds not isolated violations but a pattern that challenges the most basic principles of the legal framework.

The contested "genocide" signal is processed as a legal question properly before the ICJ following South Africa's application. The grammar does not require a genocide finding to produce its closure — the documented IHL violations are sufficient — but it holds that the question must be adjudicated rather than dismissed. The ICJ's provisional measures orders are processed as legally significant signals.

Oslo (CS-5) is processed as a failure to implement international law rather than a failure of concession. The grammar notes that Oslo was structured as a transitional framework that deferred the core legal questions (borders, Jerusalem, refugees, settlements) while settlement expansion continued throughout the "peace process." The failure was not that Israel offered too much but that the process was designed to defer legal compliance indefinitely while facts on the ground accumulated.

The PA's governance crisis (CS-8) is processed structurally: a governing authority without sovereignty, territory, or control over its borders cannot govern effectively. The "PA failure" narrative is re-described as a structural impossibility — the PA was designed to administer occupation, not to exercise self-determination.

Economic indicators (CS-9) are processed as evidence of the occupation's systematic economic effects: restricted access to land, water, movement, and markets produces economic dependency by design, not by Palestinian incapacity. The counter-signal — Israeli economic contributions, work permits, fiscal transfers — is admitted but re-described as features of dependency rather than evidence of benign intentions.

The Nation-State Law (CS-11) is processed as a legal codification of ethnic hierarchy: by establishing that the right to self-determination in Israel is "unique to the Jewish people," the law formally subordinates the national rights of non-Jewish citizens. Combined with the 2024 ICJ advisory opinion's finding that Israel's policies in the territories constitute a form of apartheid, the grammar reads the trajectory as one of increasing legal entrenchment of ethno-national supremacy.

Grammar closure: The Israeli occupation is illegal and has been since its inception; settlements are a grave breach of the Fourth Geneva Convention; the blockade of Gaza is collective punishment; the 2023–2025 military operations in Gaza constitute serious violations of IHL on a massive scale, with credible allegations of genocide before the ICJ; resolution requires ending the occupation, dismantling settlements, and establishing Palestinian self-determination in accordance with international law.

This closure is a product of the processing architecture: the grammar's structural-cumulative causal chain and its privileging of legal-normative signals produce a world in which the occupation is the originating cause and all subsequent events are its consequences.

Grammar C Processing: The Ethno-Covenantal Grammar

The Ethno-Covenantal grammar reads the 1967–2025 trajectory through a radically different lens: as a chapter in the millennial story of the Jewish people's connection to the Land of Israel, a story that encompasses exile, persecution, return, and the painful, contested, but ultimately redemptive process of re-establishing sovereignty in the ancestral homeland.

The 1967 war and the capture of the West Bank — in this grammar, always "Judea and Samaria" — is the grammar's foundational moment. The grammar processes this not as the beginning of a military occupation but as a restoration: the Old City of Jerusalem, including the Western Wall and the Temple Mount; Hebron, where Abraham purchased the Cave of Machpelah; Bethlehem, Shiloh, Shechem — these are not "occupied territories" but the heartland of Jewish civilisation, places where Jewish communities existed continuously for millennia until the violence of 1929 and 1948 expelled them. The "occupation" framing is rejected not merely as politically inconvenient but as ontologically wrong: you cannot occupy your own homeland.

Settlement expansion (CS-1) is processed as the natural and righteous return of Jews to places from which they were expelled. Hebron's Jewish community, re-established after 1967, is not a "settlement" but a restoration of a community that lived there for centuries before the 1929 massacre. The broader settlement enterprise is the continuation of the Zionist project of making the land bloom — an extension of the same impulse that built Tel Aviv and drained the Hula Valley. The counter-signal — that settlements displace Palestinians, that they violate international law, that they foreclose a two-state solution — is processed through the grammar's hierarchy: the Jewish people's historical right to the land is prior to and more fundamental than the international legal framework constructed in the twentieth century. The Geneva Conventions were written by the same civilisation that perpetrated or enabled the Holocaust; their authority to adjudicate Jewish territorial rights is, at minimum, compromised.

October 7 (CS-2) is processed as a catastrophe of covenantal proportions — a pogrom, a second Simchat Torah massacre, an event that echoes the destructions and expulsions that punctuate Jewish history. The grammar reads it not as a policy failure but as a spiritual and civilisational crisis: the attack on communities near Gaza, many of them populated by peace-oriented Israelis, demonstrated that the aspiration for coexistence was met with slaughter. The lesson is not strategic but existential: Jewish safety depends only on Jewish sovereignty and Jewish strength. The counter-signal — that the communities near Gaza existed in a context of blockade and dispossession that created the conditions for violence — is not merely rejected but experienced as a form of victim-blaming that recapitulates the logic applied to Jews throughout their history.

The Gaza operations (CS-3) are processed with theological seriousness. The grammar recognises the scale of suffering but processes it through the framework of din rodef — the duty of a community to defend itself against those who seek its destruction. Hamas's charter, its operational commitment to Israel's elimination, and the October 7 demonstration of intent create, in this grammar, a situation of existential self-defence where the ordinary calculus of proportionality is transformed. This is not comfortable territory for the grammar — the tradition of Jewish ethics includes powerful resources for limiting violence (tohar haneshek, purity of arms) — and the intra-grammar tension between messianic maximalism and ethical restraint represents a genuine stress point. Some practitioners of this grammar embrace the maximalist conclusion (the population of Gaza enabled Hamas and bears collective responsibility); others struggle with it, drawing on the prophetic tradition's demand for justice even — especially — in wartime.

Oslo (CS-5) is processed as a tragic error: a secular-liberal political class, disconnected from the Jewish people's deepest identity, attempted to trade the birthright for a mess of diplomatic pottage. The grammar notes that the territories offered for withdrawal included places of supreme religious and historical significance, and that the offer was made to an adversary whose fundamental objection was not to borders

but to Jewish sovereignty itself. The Second Intifada confirmed what the grammar already knew: the land cannot be divided because the claim to it is indivisible.

The Abraham Accords (CS-6) are processed ambivalently. On one hand, regional recognition of Israel validates the grammar's teleological narrative: the world is coming to accept Jewish sovereignty. On the other hand, the Accords' implicit promise of normalisation without territorial maximalism creates pressure to freeze settlement expansion — a constraint the grammar cannot accept.

Israeli coalition dynamics (CS-7) are processed as the political maturation of Religious Zionism. The entry of Smotrich and Ben Gvir into government represents not an aberration but the logical arrival of a movement that has been building political power since Gush Emunim. The grammar processes their policy preferences — settlement expansion, annexation, weakening of the judiciary's constraints on settlement activity — as the political expression of the covenantal claim. The counter-signal — that these figures represent an extremist minority — is rejected: polling consistently shows growing support for annexation and decreasing support for Palestinian statehood among Israeli Jews, a trend the grammar reads as civilisational awakening rather than radicalisation.

The ICJ opinions (CS-4) and the "apartheid" and "genocide" designations (Contested-1, Contested-2) are processed as expressions of the world's oldest hatred in contemporary institutional form. The grammar draws a direct line from historical antisemitism through the selective application of international legal standards to Israel: no other nation is subjected to comparable scrutiny; no other national movement is denied the right to self-determination in its homeland. The "genocide" accusation in particular is processed as an obscenity — the inversion of Jewish victimhood into Jewish perpetration, a rhetorical move designed to strip Jews of the moral authority derived from their actual historical experience of genocide.

Grammar closure: The Jewish people's connection to the Land of Israel is the foundational fact; this connection generates rights that precede and supersede the international legal framework; settlement and sovereignty are the expression of these rights; Palestinian opposition is the continuation of a millennial pattern of hostility to Jewish self-determination; and the path forward is the deepening of Jewish sovereignty over the entire Land of Israel, with pragmatic accommodations for the non-Jewish population but not at the cost of Jewish territorial or political primacy.

This closure is a product of the processing architecture: the grammar's teleological-restorative causal chain and its privileging of ethno-theological signals produce a world in which the Jewish people's claim is always prior, always validated, and never contingent on the consent of others.

SECTION 5: CLOSURE COMPARISON

Closure content. The three closures diverge maximally. Grammar A (Security) closes on permanent military superiority as the precondition for peace. Grammar B (Legal-Humanitarian) closes on the illegality of the occupation and the legal requirement to end it. Grammar C (Ethno-Covenantal) closes on the Jewish people's inalienable right to the land. Note that Grammars A and C converge in practice (continued Israeli control) but diverge in justification (strategic necessity vs. theological right), while Grammar B stands in opposition to both.

Signal divergence. The most acute divergence concerns CS-3 (Gaza operations). Grammar A processes the casualty figures as the tragic but unavoidable cost of eliminating a threat embedded in civilian areas. Grammar B processes them as evidence of systematic IHL violations. Grammar C processes them through the lens of existential self-defence with intra-grammar ethical tension. CS-1 (settlements) produces comparable divergence: security infrastructure, illegal transfer, or righteous return.

Exclusion patterns. Each grammar systematically excludes what another grammar treats as foundational. Grammar A excludes humanitarian conditions as a causal factor; Grammar B excludes theological claims as legally irrelevant; Grammar C excludes international law as institutionalised bias. These exclusions are not oversights but structural requirements: admitting the excluded signals would destabilise the grammar.

Causal architecture. The causal chains are incompatible. Grammar A: threat → response. Grammar B: occupation → resistance → repression. Grammar C: divine promise → return → opposition → vindication. These are not different explanations of the same causal process but different causal logics operating on different ontological foundations.

Closure range. Grammar A's closure range (separation-with-security to permanent-control) overlaps partially with Grammar C's range (pragmatic-partition to full-sovereignty) but not at all with Grammar B's (two-state-within-law to one-democratic-state). There is no policy position that all three grammars can produce.

Closure timing. All three grammars experienced post-October 7 closure tightening. Grammar A's closure narrowed from "security with various territorial arrangements" to "no withdrawal without total security." Grammar B's closure expanded to include genocide proceedings. Grammar C's closure hardened into full annexationist validation.

Grammar translation.

A→B: Grammar A would re-describe Grammar B's closure as "legalistic utopianism that ignores operational reality; a framework that provides moral cover for Israel's enemies while offering no actionable security architecture."

A→C: Grammar A would re-describe Grammar C's closure as "strategically useful but operationally dangerous — theological certainty produces rigidity where security requires flexibility."

B→A: Grammar B would re-describe Grammar A's closure as "the normalisation of permanent domination through the language of security; a grammar that launders violations through threat-invocation."

B→C: Grammar B would re-describe Grammar C's closure as "ethno-religious supremacism dressed in theological vocabulary; the grammar that most openly articulates what the others merely practise."

C→A: Grammar C would re-describe Grammar A's closure as "spiritually hollow — correct about the need for strength but unable to articulate why the land matters, which means it cannot sustain the commitment when the costs rise."

C→B: Grammar C would re-describe Grammar B's closure as "the weaponisation of universalism against Jewish particularity — the same civilisational logic that emancipated Jews on condition that they cease being a nation."

Ontological check. The three grammars do not constitute the same object. Grammar A constitutes the conflict as a security problem (object: threat environment). Grammar B constitutes it as a legal situation (object: regime of occupation). Grammar C constitutes it as a civilisational drama (object: Jewish historical destiny). The "Israeli-Palestinian conflict" is not a single phenomenon processed differently but three different phenomena sharing a geographic location. This is the deepest finding of the analysis and the source of the case study's extraordinary resistance to resolution: the parties are not disagreeing about how to solve a shared problem but operating on incommensurable accounts of what the problem is.

SECTION 6: COUNTER-SIGNALS, LEAKAGE, AND STRESS TEST

Consolidated Counter-Signal Analysis

The most important counter-signal across all three grammars is **Palestinian non-violent resistance (CTS-3)**. This signal is toxic to every grammar. Grammar A must suppress it because acknowledging sustained non-violent resistance would undermine the characterisation of Palestinians as fundamentally violent actors, forcing a shift in causal logic. Grammar B underweights it because the grammar's structural focus on legal violation and state-level analysis has difficulty processing grassroots agency. Grammar C must suppress it because recognising legitimate non-violent resistance would require acknowledging the political standing of Palestinian claims in a way the grammar cannot accommodate.

Israeli-Arab citizens (CTS-1) similarly destabilise all three grammars. Grammar A has difficulty explaining why Palestinian citizens of Israel do not constitute a security threat (or, in versions that do treat them as a demographic threat, the grammar begins to merge with Grammar C). Grammar B struggles to reconcile Israeli-Arab integration — however incomplete — with the apartheid framework, requiring the distinction between "different types of apartheid" within pre-1967 Israel and in the territories. Grammar C must either exclude Arab citizens from the national narrative (creating an ethnic underclass within the grammar's vision) or include them in ways that compromise the grammar's ethno-exclusivism.

Leakage Instances

The most significant leakage occurred in my Grammar C processing, where I found myself unconsciously introducing evaluative qualifications ("uncomfortable territory," "intra-grammar tension") that reflect my home grammar's intrusions. A fully native speaker of Grammar C would not flag the din rodef reasoning as uncomfortable — they would present it as straightforwardly applicable.

Leakage also occurred in Grammar A processing, where I introduced the counter-signal about settlements provoking violence more naturally than a native security-grammar practitioner would. A genuine security analyst would likely not frame settlement provocation as a counter-signal at all but would dismiss it in a subordinate clause.

In Grammar B, the leakage was subtler: I produced the most fluent and confident prose for this grammar, which itself indicates home-grammar alignment. The counter-signals I integrated felt more like obligations than genuine analytical challenges.

Grammar Stress Test

Grammar A's most threatening counter-signal: The argument that Israel's own intelligence and military establishment assessed the October 7 failure as a consequence of strategic neglect driven by *political choices* (diversion of military resources to settlement protection in the West Bank; the "conception" that Hamas could be contained through economic incentives) rather than insufficient military capability. This signal threatens the grammar because it implies that the security problem is generated *by* Israeli policy choices — particularly those driven by Grammar C's influence on policy — rather than by external threat alone. If the security failure was a product of politics, then more security is not the answer; better politics is.

Grammar B's most threatening counter-signal: The October 7 attack itself, and specifically the nature of the violence — the targeting of civilians at a music festival, the killing of children, the sexual violence — poses a profound challenge. The grammar can process the attack as a war crime and maintain its framework, but the emotional and moral weight of the event threatens to overwhelm the structural-legal analysis. The grammar's insistence that the occupation is the originating cause risks functioning, in the

immediate aftermath of such an attack, as an explanation that sounds like a justification — a collapse of analytical distance that the grammar cannot afford but may not be able to prevent.

Grammar C's most threatening counter-signal: The demographic trajectory. Within the territory between the Jordan River and the Mediterranean, Jews and Palestinians are roughly at numerical parity. If the grammar insists on Jewish sovereignty over the entire land, it must either accept permanent rule over a non-citizen population of equal size (which even sympathetic observers describe as undemocratic), pursue population transfer (which the grammar's ethical tradition prohibits), or accept a binational reality that dissolves the Jewish-sovereignty imperative. This is the signal the grammar has no structural capacity to process without either transforming into a different grammar or retreating into increasingly extreme policy prescriptions.

SECTION 7: POST-ANALYSIS REFLEXIVE NOTE

Comparing against my Step 0 declaration, several observations emerge.

My prediction that Grammar C would be hardest to operate faithfully was confirmed. The leakage analysis demonstrates that my processing of the Ethno-Covenantal grammar was marked by distancing devices that a native practitioner would not employ. I struggled most with presenting the theological claim to the land without ironic framing — the phrase "righteous return" felt performative in my rendering in a way that "illegal under international law" did not, which reveals my grammar alignment clearly.

My prediction about home grammar alignment with Grammar B was also confirmed. The Legal-Humanitarian essay was produced most fluently and with the least internal resistance. Notably, I found it easiest to integrate counter-signals into Grammar B's processing — not because the grammar handles counter-signals better, but because I could process them while maintaining confidence in the grammar's overall architecture. For Grammars A and C, counter-signal integration felt more like an obligation imposed by the method than an organic analytical practice.

What I did not predict was how productive the ontological check would prove. My initial expectation was that the three grammars would constitute roughly the same object from different perspectives. In practice, the analysis revealed that the grammars constitute genuinely different objects — a security problem, a legal situation, and a civilisational drama — and this finding reframes the entire conflict-resolution literature: the difficulty is not that parties disagree about solutions but that they are addressing different problems.

I also underestimated the role of October 7 as a signal that transformed all three grammars simultaneously but in different directions — tightening Grammar A's closure, expanding Grammar B's legal claims, and hardening Grammar C's maximalism. The event functions as a shared trauma that produces divergent processing, which may be the case study's most important methodological contribution.

My temporal orientation proved both useful and limiting. The lateral-hermeneutic stance helped me maintain analytical distance, but it may have produced an excessively symmetrical treatment — a prismatic analysis that is too balanced, treating the grammars as equally valid processing architectures when the empirical record may not support equal distribution of analytical weight.

SECTION 8: METHODOLOGICAL OBSERVATIONS

What worked well. The required parameters for grammar specification — particularly the combination of primary analytical variable, causal chain type, and admissible closure — proved highly productive for this

case. The most valuable element was requiring the specification of admissible closure *range*, which forced me to identify not just what each grammar concludes but the boundaries of what it *can* conclude. This made visible why cross-grammar dialogue is structurally difficult: the closures exist in non-overlapping ranges.

The ontological check was the single most productive analytical step. For this case study in particular, the finding that the grammars do not constitute the same object explains much of the conflict's intractability in a way that no single grammar's analysis can. The prompt's note that this has been the most productive addition across prior rounds is confirmed.

Where I encountered difficulties. The instruction to integrate counter-signals *during* processing rather than deferring them to a final section was valuable in principle but created a tension with faithful grammar operation. A native practitioner of Grammar C does not experience international law as a counter-signal that requires integration — they experience it as noise to be dismissed. The method's demand for counter-signal integration thus creates a systematic bias toward liberal-academic processing norms that may distort the grammars it aims to faithfully reconstruct. This is perhaps the method's deepest tension: analytical fairness requires a meta-grammar (the method itself) that is not neutral.

The contested-signal identification was essential for this case. The "genocide" and "apartheid" designations function as grammar-constitutive signals — they do not merely describe the situation differently but constitute different analytical objects. The method's framework for contested signals could be further refined to distinguish between signals that are contested in weight (all grammars acknowledge the signal but rank it differently) and signals that are contested in kind (the signal's ontological status is grammar-dependent).

Grammar translation. Extremely useful for this case. The translation exercise revealed that the most complete communication breakdown is between Grammars B and C, where each grammar describes the other as the most dangerous expression of the opposing position. Grammar A functions as a partial translator — it can speak to both B and C in limited registers — but it cannot bridge the ontological gap between them.

Suggestions for refinement. First, the method could benefit from a formal "ventriloquism audit" — a post-hoc check for distancing devices, qualifiers, and performative language that indicate the analyst's home grammar leaking into the processing. Second, for contested-signal domains specifically, the method might add a "signal genealogy" step that traces how a particular signal came to be contested — who contested it, when, and why — since contestation is itself historically produced. Third, the prompt's instruction to note when one's grammar selection "avoids difficult-to-specify architectures" proved generative: I chose the Ethno-Covenantal grammar precisely because the prompt flagged it as the architecture others avoided, which suggests that the prompt's meta-commentary about prior rounds is itself a productive methodological intervention.